part of it to the state at the rates specified by the government. These farmers had no ownership of the land they tilled; they did not have any permanent right of tenancy and could be ejected at the will of the zamindar. These peasants, thus, had no direct relationship with the state in any manner.

Second, in the rest of the country, under the ryotwari system, there was no formal intermediary and the farmer was ostensibly in a direct relationship of tax payment with the state. However, in practice, there were numerous intermediaries, acting under different authorities granted and assumed, who lorded over the farmers. The tenurial standing of the farmer was also not very clear and coded in laws.

States started enacting their land tenancy laws in 1948. Erstwhile Bombay State passed its land tenancy law in 1948, which later became applicable to Maharashtra and Gujarat. Rajasthan passed its law in 1955 and the longstanding Bihar Tenancy Act, 1885, was amended in the 1950s and 1960s to provide for tenancy, land consolidation and other reforms.

West Bengal, under the Left Front government, went one step further. Sharecropping was a very common arrangement in rural India. The farmer would take land from the recorded landowner and pay a share of the produce to the owner; the share depended on several factors, such as who would provide inputs, etc.

As land leasing was illegal in almost the entire country, the sharecropping system was completely informal. West Bengal decided to convert sharecropper cultivators (called *bargadars*) into permanent tenants. About 1.5 million bargadars were provided permanent tenancy in Operation Barga in the state, which concluded sometime in the 1980s.

The legislations abolishing the zamindari system and intermediaries achieved a significant transformation of the countryside by enlarging the base of land ownership. As a result of the implementation of these laws, ownership of nearly 40 per cent of cultivable land was transferred to direct producers. Further, under the tenancy laws, nearly 12.4 million tenants